



THE SOCIETY OF POLYMATHS

Founding Charter

Purpose, Vision, Axioms and Rules

Institute of Mathematics
University of the Punjab, Lahore

STATUS OF THIS DOCUMENT

The Society of Polymaths is an independent, student-run community. It is not registered with, recognised by, or affiliated to the University of the Punjab, its Institute of Mathematics, or any other institution or authority. This Charter records the Society's principles; it does not create a legal entity and does not speak for the University.

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1. PREAMBLE

The Society of Polymaths is a student society that began in the Institute of Mathematics, University of the Punjab, Lahore. The University is a public institution whose students come from many cities, schools and backgrounds. It has some university-wide societies, but few departments have societies of their own, and the Institute had none. The Society was started to offer one.

Its members have asked for a clear statement of what the Society is for and how it intends to conduct itself. This Charter is that statement. It is kept short and general on purpose. It sets out the Society's purpose, vision, founding principles and basic rules, and it is expected to be revised as the Society grows.

2. PURPOSE

The purpose of the Society is to bring students together to think critically, to work across disciplines, and to use what they learn for the public good.

The Society is not a substitute for the University's teaching, and it is not a political, religious or commercial body. Its aim is to give students a place to explore ideas beyond the syllabus, to work with people from other fields, and to put their knowledge and skills to use for others.

3. VISION

The Society hopes to become a lasting and welcoming community of inquiry at the Institute of Mathematics, open to students of every background. In such a community, ideas are examined honestly and disagreement is treated as a normal part of learning; people from different disciplines work together; and knowledge is used to help others beyond the classroom. The Society hopes to continue under new members as older ones graduate, and to be a community from which other departments can learn.

4. AXIOMS

The following seven axioms are the foundations of the Society. The first three are its pillars; the remaining four describe how it exists and is organised. The activities and rules in the later sections follow from them, and where a rule conflicts with an axiom, the axiom prevails.

Axiom I (Critical thinking). *Assumptions may be questioned, and inquiry is open, honest and free from dogma.*

Members ask for reasons and evidence, examine ideas rather than persons, and are willing to change their minds. No belief or opinion, including those held within the Society, is exempt from honest analysis.

Axiom II (Interdisciplinary collaboration and inclusivity). *Ideas are approached across the boundaries of science, technology, philosophy and the arts, and every student is welcome to take part.*

Problems are often understood best from more than one angle. Participation does not depend on department, year of study, grades, school, city, language, religion, sect, gender or economic circumstance.

Axiom III (Public good). *The Society's knowledge and skills are used to make a tangible, positive contribution to others.*

Members aim to be judged by what they improve as well as by what they discuss. Service is offered with respect for the people it is meant to help.

Axiom IV (Independence). *The Society is a community-led effort, not affiliated with, funded by, or governed by any institution or authority.*

This concerns the Society's direction and its freedom to think. It does not place the Society or its members outside the laws of Pakistan or the regulations of the University. The Society is non-partisan and non-sectarian.

Axiom V (Voluntary participation). *There are no fees, rigid commitments or obligations; members take part when and as they wish.*

Members may join, step back and return at will.

Axiom VI (Evolving structure). *The Society begins as an informal group and develops structure only as its needs require.*

It avoids heavy procedure and bureaucracy. Rules are added when a real need arises and are kept simple.

Axiom VII (Individual responsibility). *Every member acts solely in a personal capacity.*

Members are responsible for their own words and actions, and the Society does not direct what they do outside its activities. Views expressed by a member are the member's own. The Society is not a legal entity.

5. ACTIVITIES

The Society's activities take four forms. Each is open to every member, and none is compulsory.

Discussions and debates. Informal but rigorous conversations on ethics, philosophy, science and social trends, and structured debates.

Content creation, research and projects. Collaboration on essays, research notes and creative work; independent research; and other projects, including online academic tools and content that help the wider community.

Competitions and challenges. Arranging and taking part in intellectually rich and competitive activities, such as debates, hackathons, competitive programming, robotics, mathematics and other STEM competitions, creative showcases, problem-solving sprints, and literature or general-knowledge quizzes.

Volunteering and community service. Direct, practical work for the community: building, volunteering, or helping anybody in any way the Society reasonably can, from an awareness campaign to hands-on assistance.

These are examples of the kind of work the Society is for, not a fixed programme. Any member is free to propose others.

6. RULES

The rules below follow from the axioms. They are deliberately few, and the members may change them (Section 6.6).

6.1 Membership

Any student who shares the axioms may take part. The Society began at the Institute of Mathematics but is open to students of other departments and institutions. There is no application and no fee; membership consists of taking part. A member may leave at any time.

6.2 Conduct

Members are expected to:

- (a) treat others with respect, and disagree with ideas rather than with persons;
- (b) refrain from harassment, bullying and discrimination of any kind;
- (c) discuss religious, political and social questions as subjects of inquiry, courteously and in good faith, without mocking any belief and without using the Society to campaign for a party, movement or sect;
- (d) respect one another's privacy, and not share another member's personal details, messages or photographs without consent;
- (e) give credit for the work and ideas of others, and not use the Society to assist plagiarism or cheating; and
- (f) act within the law and the regulations of the University.

A member who repeatedly disregards these expectations may be asked to leave, after the matter has been discussed with them.

6.3 Coordination and decisions

The Society is coordinated by its founder together with any members who choose to help. Coordinators keep the community running and uphold this Charter; they facilitate and do not command. Decisions are made by open discussion and, where necessary, by a vote of the members. No one speaks on behalf of the Society without the agreement of its members. Decisions and activities are recorded simply and are open to members. Since students graduate, coordinators should encourage and prepare others to take over.

6.4 Activities and resources

Any member may propose an activity, which proceeds under the Society's name with the support of other members. Activities are open to members and free of charge. The Society collects no dues and holds no funds, and it accepts no support that would compromise its independence. Where an activity needs a venue or permission from the University or any other authority, its organisers seek it in their own capacity and do not present the Society as official. Organisers take reasonable care for the safety of participants. Members keep ownership of their own work, and contributors are credited.

6.5 Responsibility and limits

Members take part in a personal capacity and at their own responsibility. The Society is not a legal entity, and this Charter creates no legal relationship between members. Nothing in it overrides the law or the regulations of the University.

6.6 Amendment

Any member may propose a change to this Charter, and changes are decided by the members after open discussion. Because the axioms are the Society's foundations, they should be changed only with particular care and with wider agreement than other provisions. Each revision is numbered and dated.

7. RECOGNITION AND AFFILIATION

The Society has not yet decided whether to seek recognition or affiliation, whether with the University or with any external body, and this Charter does not decide the matter. In the meantime the Society builds its community, carries out activities, and keeps a simple record of them. If the members choose to seek recognition, then:

- (a) the decision is made openly by the members;
- (b) the terms are explained to every member beforehand;
- (c) recognition is not accepted at the cost of the axioms; and
- (d) until it is granted, the Society does not describe itself as officially recognised.

8. ADOPTION

This Charter takes effect when it is shared with the members, and it remains open to their comments and suggestions. In keeping with the first axiom, members are encouraged to question it and to propose improvements.

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